

Early Japan

Over a period of about 15,000 years, the people who lived on the Japanese islands in ancient times slowly developed from small and isolated communities of simple hunter-gatherers into complex farming societies with a distinct culture.

Historians and archaeologists aren't sure when humans first reached Japan, although it might have been as early as 35,000 BCE. The age we now call "early Japan" began around 14,000 BCE with the Jomon period. The Jomon people made pottery with a distinctive rope or cord pattern, and formed the earliest communities in Japan. They lived near rivers or the sea, and survived by hunting, fishing, and gathering.

Jomon communities declined around 300 BCE. They were replaced by the Yayoi people, who may have traveled to the Japanese islands from the Korean Peninsula or mainland

China. The Yayoi people formed clans, each with a male leader, although women may have also served in this role. Clan heads were also the religious and military leaders of their communities. The various clans often fought each other, and the victors absorbed the defeated clan and its lands into their own.

As some clans began to become larger and more powerful, their culture evolved. The most powerful clan was the Yamato, who conquered all of Japan by the 3rd century CE. This began an era known as the Kofun period, which lasted until the 6th century CE.

FACT

The method of growing rice in flooded fields was introduced to Japan by people who migrated from eastern parts of mainland China.

Reconstructed longhouse



PIT-HOUSES ►

Many people in early Japan lived in "pit houses"—dwellings that consisted of a sloping roof built over a large hole in the ground, so part of the house was underground. The roofs were covered with grass that helped make them rainproof.



Pitched, thatched roof

◄ MAGATAMA JEWELRY

By around 1000 BCE, the people of Japan began making jewelry with curved, comma-shaped beads called magatama. The beads were made from natural materials such as stone, clay, quartz, or jade. It is thought that the beads were carved to resemble the animal teeth seen on prehistoric jewelry.

Jade beads were used for the necklace.

